

Frostcup Coffee — The Minus-86 Latte

An iced latte so cold it sells itself.

What It Is

Frostcup is a café (or cart/kiosk concept) built around one unforgettable visual: serving lattes in cups pre-frozen to around -86°C in an ultra-low-temperature freezer. The cup comes out crusted in white frost, and fresh espresso and milk are poured straight into it — keeping the drink ice cold for far longer without melting ice watering it down. The frost-covered cup is the product *and* the marketing.

How It Makes Money

Standard café economics with a viral premium. Customers pay a few dollars more for the experience and the photo. The real leverage is free reach: every customer who films the frosted cup advertises you to their followers, so you spend almost nothing on marketing and convert that attention into a steady line of paying visitors and repeat regulars.

Startup Costs

- Ultra-low-temperature (-86°C) lab/chest freezer (Alibaba — "minus 86 ULT laboratory freezer"): **\$2,500–\$6,000**; a -40°C unit works for a softer version at **\$1,200–\$2,500**.
- Espresso machine + grinder (commercial entry-level): **\$2,500–\$6,000**.
- Double-wall or frost-safe cups/glasses, sourced in bulk: **\$0.30–\$1.20 each**.
- Cart/kiosk or small lease + basic buildout: **\$3,000–\$25,000** depending on format (start with a cart).
- POS, branding, signage, permits, food handler license: **\$1,500–\$4,000**.
- **Lean start (cart format): ~\$10,000–\$20,000.**

The Numbers

Cost to make one frozen latte: $\$0.50 \text{ milk} + \$0.35 \text{ coffee} + \$0.40 \text{ cup/lid} = \text{\$1.25 per drink}$. Sell at **\$6–\$8** (premium justified by the experience) = **\$4.75–\$6.75 gross profit per cup**. A modest 80 cups/day at \$7 = **\$560/day revenue**, ~\$100 COGS, ~\$460 gross. Over 26 days ≈ **\$14,500 revenue/month**, roughly **\$7,000–\$9,000 profit** after rent, labor, and utilities on a cart. A busy storefront pushing 200+ cups/day scales this 2–3x.

How To Start

1. Pick your format — start with a cart or kiosk to keep buildout cheap, then graduate to a storefront once the concept proves out.
2. Source a ULT (or -40°C) freezer and a reliable espresso setup; test how long different cups hold frost.
3. Lock your signature drink and 3–4 menu variations; dial in a recipe that photographs beautifully.
4. Get food-handler permits and a location with foot traffic and good lighting for photos.
5. Build a content corner — a clean, well-lit spot where the frosted cup looks incredible on camera.
6. Soft-launch with a "free first 50 cups for a tag/post" promo to seed social proof.
7. Post the frosted-cup pour daily on TikTok/Instagram Reels and let user content compound.

Where To Get Customers

TikTok and Instagram Reels are the engine — the frost-crusting pour is naturally shareable. Add Google Maps optimization, a launch-day giveaway, partnerships with local micro-influencers, and a loyalty card to convert the curious into regulars.

Pro Tips

- Engineer the moment: serve it slowly, hand it over while the frost is thickest, and put a "tag us" sign right at the pickup counter — the post is the ad.
- Safety first with ULT cups: use insulated sleeves and brief staff on safe handling so nobody gets a cold burn; it protects you and the brand.
- Rotate limited seasonal frost drinks to keep regulars posting; novelty is your cheapest, highest-ROI marketing channel.